

A course in language creation



Conlangs University

Nouns 1

Part 3: Class



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Noun class

One thing that tends to give English speakers a hard time when learning other languages is **grammatical gender**, the idea that words belong to a certain category and that other words around them have to agree with that category. In many familiar Indo-European languages, gender breaks down into masculine, feminine, and sometimes neuter. Learning an Indo-European language like Spanish you might think "Why are your hands feminine but your feet are masculine? Why is spoon feminine but knife is masculine? This is all arbitrary!" You're mostly right. These genders aren't entirely tied to the "masculine/feminine" categorization that people used to talk about them. The genders in Indo-European languages are an example of a broader phenomenon known as noun class.

A **noun class** is a category that nouns belong to that is reflected through agreement in other parts of the sentence. It's common to see agreement in noun class between the head of the noun phrase and its other parts like articles, adjectives, and numerals, as well as between the verb and the subject's class or between a pronoun and the word it's replacing. Nouns can be classified in a number of ways. Classes can be semantically motivated, meaning that the class a word belongs to is determined by something about the word's meaning, phonologically motivated, meaning that something about the sound of a word determines its noun class, or it can be purely lexical and assigned idiosyncratically to each word.

Grammatical gender like in Spanish is a mix of these. Words referring to individuals or animals that can be described as masculine or feminine. Otherwise, words ending in **-o** tend to be masculine and words ending in **-a** tend to be feminine. Then there are some exceptions that aren't really predictable at all like **mano** 'hand' which is feminine, even though it ends with an **-o**. Gender is determined not by the word itself, but by the sorts of agreement patterns it causes on other words.

1. Lávense las manos.
láv -en =se las mano-s
wash-3.PL.SBJ=3RFL the.F.PL hand-PL
"Wash your hands."

Some languages have noun classes with stronger semantic motivation. Many languages in the Algonquian family distinguish two classes: animate, for things that are living, and inanimate for things that are not. The Pama-Nyungan language Dyirbal (in)famously distinguishes four noun classes: I. men and animate objects, II. women, fire, water, dangerous things, III. edible fruit and vegetables, IV. everything else. It's common to have one particular noun class designated to take in "everything else". It's known as the default or "residue" class. Bantu languages famously include over *twenty* distinct noun classes, each with its own set of agreement prefixes. Agreement with all these prefixes can lead to alliteration, like in this example from Swahili (Bantu, Niger-Congo).

2. Kitabu kikubwu kilianguka.
ki- tabu ki- kubwu ki- li- anguka
CL:I-book CL:I-big CL:I-PST-fall
"The big book fell,"

It's worth noting that some of the numbered noun classes in Bantu languages are plurals of others, so while the number of agreement paradigms can be over twenty, a particular noun will only belong to one of twelve or so singular classes and its plural to a corresponding plural class. Many of these classes have some sort of general semantic similarities, for example in Swahili classes 1 and 2 contain words for people, 3 and 4 contain words for plants, and 16-18 contain words having to do with locations. The boundaries aren't too strict though, and many classes have vague or undefined semantics.

Some languages have noun classes with purely phonological motivation. In Guébie (Kru, Niger-Congo), there are three singular inanimate pronouns, **e**, **a**, and **u**. These same three sounds are also used as adjective agreement suffixes. Which one you use is determined entirely by a word's phonology. If the final vowel of the noun you're agreeing with is high and front, you use **e**, if the final vowel is high and back you use **u**, and if it's low you use **a**. Adding suffixes to a word can change its agreement class if it changes the final vowel, so we know agreement is tied to the sound rather than the word. When speakers hear made-up words, they consistently choose to use the phonological agreement pattern, so we know it's productive. This sort of completely phonological system is rare, but it's cool, eh?